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THA 213: Theatre History from the Renaissance to the 19th Century

How revolutions, technology and money rebuilt the stage

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

This pack links theatre change to political and industrial change: the Renaissance recovery of classical texts, the rise of commercial playhouses, the director, melodrama, minstrel shows and new stage technology. It also shows you how the history sequence was renumbered between the 2018 and 2019 departmental listings.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Trace major European theatre developments from the Renaissance to 1900.
- Explain how industrial and political change shaped theatre architecture and production.
- Connect the rise of the director to changes in staging and rehearsal.
- Interpret the archive entries showing how the department reorganised this course.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Renaissance to Enlightenment

Recovered classical texts changed what could be staged and how.

- Humanist scholarship revived Roman comedy and Senecan tragedy.
- Commedia dell'arte professionalised touring improvisation.
- Court masque and spectacle fused design, music and politics.
- Neoclassical rules constrained structure until Romantic practice broke them.
- Purpose-built playhouses created a paying public and a commercial profession.

- Printing made plays available as literature, not only as performance.

Revolution, industry and melodrama

The 19th century is the hinge between repertory theatre and modern production.

- Political revolution changed censorship, audiences and subject matter.
- Gas and later electric lighting enabled picture-stage realism and controlled mood.
- Railways created touring circuits and star actors with national reputations.
- Melodrama offered clear morality, spectacle and music to mass audiences.
- Minstrel shows spread racist caricature while shaping popular entertainment formats.
- Realism and naturalism responded with claims to scientific observation.

> **Technology is dramaturgy**
> Lighting, scene-shifting machinery and proscenium staging did not merely decorate plays; they changed what writers could write.

The rise of the director

Directing emerged as a profession when production became too complex for the actor-manager alone.

- Ensemble coherence replaced star-centred staging in key companies.
- Rehearsal became a structured period rather than a formality.
- Designers and directors coordinated unified visual concepts.
- Scripts were interpreted rather than simply recited.
- The director's authority also centralised power in production.
- This history explains why directing is a separate course in your programme.

Why stages changed when the world changed

Theatre history is easiest to remember as a chain of cause and effect between three things: who paid, what was believed, and what could be built. In the medieval period the church funded performance and belief organised the material, so plays were cycles staged on pageant wagons or in churchyards, moving through a town rather than sitting in a building.

The Renaissance rearranged all three. Courts and academies paid, humanist learning made classical texts desirable, and the invention of perspective painting supplied a technique for representing distance. Once you can paint a street receding to a vanishing point, you can build a set that imitates it, and once you do that, the audience must sit in one place to see it correctly. The proscenium arch is the architectural result of a way of seeing.

This is the single most useful idea for exam answers on this period: the picture-frame stage is not a neutral container. It decides where the audience sits, what they can see, and what kind of illusion the production is trying to produce.

The English Renaissance stage and the Spanish corral

The Elizabethan public playhouse was open-air, roughly circular, with a thrust stage projecting into a yard where groundlings stood, galleries around the walls, and a roofed rear stage with a trap. Daylight lit the performance and the audience could see each other, so the actor addressed the crowd directly and scenery was minimal; place was established in language, which is why Shakespeare's characters tell you where they are.

The Spanish corral worked on similar principles - a courtyard, a raised stage, standing groundlings, galleries and a women's gallery - with companies organised around a lead actor-manager and a repertoire that changed daily. Comparison is a strong exam move: two commercial, open-air, daylight theatres developed comparable solutions because they faced comparable constraints, not because one copied the other.

Both systems produced repertory practice: many plays in rotation, short rehearsal, actors specialised in types (the "line" system), and scripts written to the strengths of a company. Understanding repertory explains a lot of apparent oddities in the plays, including why some roles are written for particular voices and why doubling is built into the text.

> **The lighting argument**
> Daylight theatre produces a performance that acknowledges the audience; candlelit and gaslit theatre produces one that can hide from it. Lighting is a dramaturgical fact, not decoration.

Neoclassicism, the eighteenth century and the rise of the box set

French neoclassical theory, distilled from Aristotle and Horace, imposed the unities of action, time and place and a strict separation of tragedy from comedy. The rules were defended as rationality and attacked as pedantry; what matters for your answer is that they were a critical programme with a political dimension, tied to court culture and to the idea of a regulated public taste.

The eighteenth century professionalised the audience experience: subscription seasons, star actors, patent theatres in London, and a growing middle-class public that wanted domestic stories. Sentimental comedy and bourgeois tragedy answered that demand. Meanwhile the actor-manager became the dominant figure, and the actor's performance - rather than the playwright's text - began to drive the evening.

By the nineteenth century, romanticism rejected the unities in favour of historical spectacle, and the box set (three walls and a ceiling, with the fourth wall imagined) enclosed the action in a room. Gas lighting, then electric, allowed the auditorium to be darkened, which completed the picture-frame logic: the audience becomes invisible and the stage becomes a world. Realism in acting and playwriting follows from that arrangement.

Money, censorship and the profession

Every period in this course is also an economic story. Theatres were commercial ventures with shareholders, seasons, ticket prices and risk. Censorship shaped what could be written: England's licensing of plays restricted political and religious content for centuries, and the French system tied repertoire to the state. When censorship loosens, subject matter moves; when it tightens, playwrights displace the argument into history or allegory.

Companies, not individual geniuses, made the work. Repertory, stock roles, apprenticeships and touring circuits determined what was performable. If you can describe the company structure behind a period, you can explain its plays better than a student who only memorises dates.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 213

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 113 Theatre History in Perspective: 500 BC - 1800 AD appears in the 2018 descriptions
- Covers myth, folklore, songs, riddles and legends growing into written plays
- Questions whether theatre "evolved", "developed" or was "made" in various contexts

What changed: THA 113 is the older history code. It appears in the 2018 description and is absent from the 2019 programme listing.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 213 Critical Perspectives in Theatre History: Renaissance to 19th Century, 3 credits
- Covers the Industrial Revolution, nationalisms, Romanticism, melodrama, minstrel shows, acting companies and the rise of the director
- New theatre architecture and design included in the same course

What changed: The 2019 listing replaces the broad 500 BC - 1800 AD survey with a Renaissance-to-19th-century course at 200 level.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- The Renaissance-to-19th-century framing survives in the compiled 2025/2026 map
- Industrialisation, lighting technology and the emergence of the director remain examined themes
- Check whether THA 113-style world history is now covered in THA 111 or THA 112

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Answering "how did the proscenium arch change acting?"

A common exam question with a trap: students describe architecture and stop.

1. State the architectural change: a framed opening, auditorium darkened, audience separated from performers.
2. Trace the consequence for sightlines: the actor must face front and stay within the frame, so upstage/downstage blocking replaces the open thrust.
3. Trace the consequence for style: gesture becomes smaller and more facial, because the audience is closer optically even when far away physically.
4. Trace the consequence for illusion: the actor can "ignore" the audience, which makes naturalistic behaviour possible.
5. Give a counter-example: popular and political theatre kept direct address, showing that the frame was a choice, not a necessity.
6. Conclude that staging arrangements train acting conventions.

> **What to carry forward**
> Architecture to sightline to style: three links, each stated, is a full-mark answer.

2. Comparing two national traditions without listing them

You must compare the English playhouse and the Spanish corral in a timed essay.

1. Set the comparison criteria first: funding, space, audience composition, repertoire practice.
2. Compare within each criterion rather than describing one theatre then the other.
3. Identify the shared constraint: daylight, open air, commercial risk.
4. Identify the divergence: company organisation and the role of the actor-manager.
5. Explain why divergence occurred using evidence about ownership and patronage.
6. Close by arguing that similarity came from constraint and difference from institutions.

> **What to carry forward**
> Compare criterion by criterion, never theatre by theatre.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. To what extent was the picture-frame stage a product of Renaissance perspective rather than of audience demand?

20 marks

1. Explain perspective scenery and its requirement of a single viewing point.
2. Show the court and academy context that funded it.
3. Argue the audience side: indoor halls, paying spectators, desire for spectacle and comfort.
4. Use the English exception to show that demand alone did not produce the frame.
5. Conclude that technique supplied the means and commercial indoor theatre supplied the motive.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Treating perspective as a neutral technical advance. It was a way of seeing with social consequences.

Q2. How did lighting technology alter dramatic writing between 1600 and 1900?

15 marks

1. Daylight: direct address, minimal scenery, place established in language.
2. Candle and oil: indoor intimacy, selective visibility, evening performances.
3. Gas and electricity with dimming: darkened auditorium, focus on the actor, fourth wall.
4. Show one playwriting consequence: the drawing-room scene with concealed information becomes possible.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Proscenium arch. The framed opening separating stage from auditorium, typical of picture-frame theatre.

Thrust stage. A stage projecting into the auditorium with audience on three sides.

Groundling. A spectator standing in the yard of an open-air playhouse.

Corral. The Spanish courtyard playhouse, with raised stage, yard and galleries.

Box set. A realistic interior with three walls and a ceiling, the fourth wall imagined.

Unities. Neoclassical rules of action, time and place derived from Aristotle and Horace.

Repertory. A system of rotating several plays in performance rather than running one.

Line of business. The stock role type an actor specialised in within a repertory company.

Actor-manager. A performer who also ran the company, choosing repertoire and staging.

Patent theatre. A London theatre holding a royal licence to perform spoken drama.

Vanishing point. The point where receding lines meet in perspective scenery, fixing the ideal seat.

Fourth wall. The invisible boundary through which the audience watches a naturalistic production.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Medieval to Renaissance

Cause and effect.

- Draw the chain from patronage to staging.
- Label a playhouse diagram from memory.
- Write 400 words on perspective and seating.

Week 2 - England and Spain

Comparison.

- Build a four-criterion comparison table.
- Find one play that reflects repertory conditions.
- Practise a compare-by-criterion paragraph.

Week 3 - Neoclassicism to romanticism

Rules and revolt.

- Summarise the unities in three sentences.
- List three romantic objections to them.
- Trace one censorship case.

Week 4 - Realism

Lighting and the box set.

- Explain how dimming enabled naturalism.
- Describe a box set in production terms.
- Write a timed 20-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any standard theatre history survey covering the Renaissance to the nineteenth century.
- A study of Shakespearean playhouse reconstruction and its evidence.
- A history of stage lighting for the shift from daylight to gas and electricity.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. How did gas lighting change theatre practice?

Answer: It allowed controllable dimming and focus, making picture-stage realism and mood shifts possible and changing rehearsal and design practice.

2. Why did the director emerge as a profession in the 19th century?

Answer: Growing production complexity, ensemble ideals and unified visual concepts required someone to coordinate staging, design and interpretation.

3. What characterises melodrama?

Answer: Clear moral polarities, heightened emotion, music, spectacle and stock situations designed for mass audiences.

4. Name one effect of the printing press on drama.

Answer: Plays circulated as read literature, extending their influence beyond performance and shaping ideas of authorship.

5. What did neoclassical rules require?

Answer: Adherence to unity of time, place and action, decorum and clear moral instruction, modelled on classical precedent.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a timeline from 1500 to 1900 with ten theatre events.
- [ ] Explain three effects of industrialisation on theatre.
- [ ] Compare pre- and post-lighting scene changes.
- [ ] Learn five melodrama conventions with an example.
- [ ] Trace how the director's role emerged in two countries.
- [ ] Read one play from the period and note its staging demands.
- [ ] Summarise the archive change from THA 113 to the current sequence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

THA 213: Theatre History from the Renaissance to the 19th Century